



youth & adult **mission**



**When a School
Becomes a Mission Field**

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T = stories of special interest to teens

Dear Sabbath School Leader,

Gina Wahlen
Editor



This quarter we feature the Trans-European Division, which oversees the Seventh-day Adventist Church's work in the following countries and territories: Aland Islands, Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Croatia, Denmark, Estonia, Faroe Islands, Finland, Ireland, Isle of Man, Jersey, Latvia, Lithuania, Montenegro, Netherlands, North Macedonia, Norway, Poland, Serbia, Slovenia, Sweden, the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, and the southern portion of Cyprus.

The region is home to 208.3 million people, including 91,496 Adventists. That's a

ratio of one Adventist for every 2,276 people.

Part of a special offering collected on the last Sabbath of this quarter will go to support four projects in Finland, Poland, Croatia, and the United Kingdom. Those Thirteenth Sabbath projects are listed in the sidebar.

This quarter takes you behind the scenes in these four countries to see how God is working in wonderful ways, touching the lives of people and using them to bless others. I'm sure you, and those with whom you share, will be inspired as I was when I listened to these people share their stories.

Special Features

If you want to make your Sabbath school class come alive this quarter, we offer photos, videos, and other materials to accompany each mission story. More information is provided in the sidebar with each story.

Follow us at facebook.com/missionquarterlies/ to read and share stories and download pictures and short videos illustrating the stories.

Download the PDF version of the Youth/Adult Mission quarterlies at am.adventistmission.org/mq-adult, and the *Children's Mission* quarterly at am.adventistmission.org/mq-children.

Mission Spotlight videos are available completely free to download or stream at am.adventistmission.org/mission-spotlight.

Thank you for your support of Adventist Mission around the world—being grounded in the Bible and focused on the mission!

Opportunities

This quarter's Thirteenth Sabbath Offering, also known as the Quarterly Mission Project Offering, will support four projects in the Trans-European Division:

- Establishing the Family Mission Center OIKOS church plant, Helsinki, Finland
- Expanding KOMPAS, the first Adventist Primary School in Poland, Podkowa Lesna, Poland
- Rebuilding the Seventh-day Adventist Church, Zagreb, Croatia
- Provide "SafeSpace2B" outreach hubs in community schools, England, United Kingdom

Finding Family on the Streets of Helsinki



FINLAND | October 3

Jenny

Jenny wasn't looking for a church that winter day in Helsinki's city center—she was praying for friends.

Only three months earlier, she had begun a personal journey of faith. While waiting for her mother at a doctor's appointment, Jenny wandered through the streets, quietly asking God for Christian community. Almost immediately, she felt impressed to walk down a particular street near a busy square.

That decision changed everything.

There, she met a small group from OIKOS House, a Seventh-day Adventist church plant in Helsinki. One of the outreach volunteers approached her with an unexpected question: *"Has anyone ever written a poem for you?"* When she said no, he asked her to share three words. One of them was "peace."

As they talked, Jenny admitted she believed in God, but she didn't yet realize the group was Christian. When they explained

they were inviting people to church, another volunteer, Linda, shared about OIKOS House. Contact information was exchanged, and a simple invitation followed.

At first, Jenny hesitated. But she trusted the same God who had led her down that street. "I wasn't afraid," she later said. "I knew this was from Him."

Two weeks later, she rang the doorbell of the OIKOS House.

"I was expecting a church building," Jenny recalled with a smile. "I thought, *What if there's just a family having dinner inside?* But I prayed, *'Lord, You led me here—so keep leading me.'*"

She was welcomed warmly. Worship flowed naturally into small-group conversations, and strangers quickly became friends. "It felt like family right away," she said. "So, I just kept coming."

Jenny grew up with a mixed religious background, with her parents coming from two different religions. But going to church was never a consistent part of her life. As a young adult, she lived a secular lifestyle and found herself in a painful relationship that left her emotionally broken.

"I was miserable and searching for something to hold onto," she said. "I knew about God, and that was my last hope." In desperation she prayed, *"If You are really there, please help me."*

God answered.



As Jenny began forming a personal relationship with Jesus, she found the strength to leave the relationship and her old way of life behind. In prayer, God also did something she never thought possible—He removed her anger and bitterness.

“I realized I didn’t hate him [the boyfriend who had cheated on her] anymore,” she said. “And I told him that Jesus had taken the anger away.” Through forgiveness, Jenny was able to share the gospel with her former boyfriend—something she says she could never have done on her own.

After stepping away from her old life, Jenny experienced a quiet season of growth—time with God, her family, and prayer for new friends. Those prayers were answered through OIKOS House.

“What I love most about OIKOS is that it’s family,” she said. “Everyone is welcome as they are. People from so many backgrounds—and it just works.”

Through that community, Jenny met Timi, who had been part of the original OIKOS core team. Their friendship grew into a relationship rooted in faith, prayer, and purpose. After nine months of dating, they became engaged during the ARISE discipleship program and were married in July 2025.

Jenny also participated in ARISE Finland, a three-month discipleship and outreach program held in eastern Finland. There, Bible study, community living, and hands-on outreach deepened her faith.

“The most important thing I learned,” she said, “was that God is love. When you see that, the whole Bible comes together.”

Today, Jenny is studying early childhood education at the University of Helsinki, preparing for a future of service. She and Timi live near OIKOS House, just minutes from where she first rang the doorbell.

Looking back, Jenny sees God’s hand clearly: from a simple prayer on a city street to a spiritual family, a restored life, and a heart ready for mission.

“I didn’t connect the dots at first,” she said.

Story Tips

- Show the location of Helsinki, Finland on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to Finland (see below)

Mission Post

- The first Seventh-day Adventist in Finland was a sea captain—A. F. Lundqvist, who, while docked at Liverpool, England in 1885, bought Uriah Smith’s *Daniel and the Revelation* and Ellen White’s *The Great Controversy* from a colporteur. He remained a faithful church member until his death in 1955, aged 97.
- The first Church worker in Finland was a Swedish canvassing leader, Emil Lind, who was sent to Finland in 1891. He found the work difficult and was even threatened with exile to Siberia.
- In 1892, the Swedish Conference president, Olof Johnson, and two Bible workers, Augusta Larsson and Matilda Lindgren, came to Helsinki. Because foreigners could not hold public meetings, Johnson held them in his own home.

“But now I see—God was leading me the whole way.” 🌍

Across Finland, many young adults, like Jenny, are searching for community, purpose, and a place where faith feels personal and lived. Part of this quarter’s Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will help OIKOS House expand that ministry by launching a new church plant designed especially for families. Just as a simple invitation on a Helsinki street led Jenny to spiritual family and new life in Christ, your mission offerings help create spaces where others can encounter God, find belonging, and begin their own journey of faith.

Every Step a Battle

FINLAND | October 10

Joe



Joe almost turned back more than once. The Sabbath morning he first came to OIKOS House in Helsinki, everything inside him resisted going. Though he had recently begun his journey of faith, anxiety pressed hard as he left his home, walked to the train station, boarded the train, and then walked again toward an unfamiliar house.

“It felt like every step was a battle,” Joe recalled. “I didn’t know about spiritual warfare then—but I know now that something didn’t want me to come.”

The final walk from the station should have taken five minutes. Instead, it took fifteen—and three prayers.

Standing outside the door, Joe hesitated. *What if this is the wrong place? What if they don’t accept me?* he thought. He pressed the doorbell, telling himself that if no one answered within five seconds, he would run home.

The door opened almost immediately.

With warm smiles and a genuine welcome, the fear that had followed Joe all morning vanished. “It was like crossing a barrier,” he said. “The anxiety disappeared the moment I stepped inside.”

For the first time, church felt different.

Joe’s journey to that doorstep began long

before Finland. Born in Thailand to a Finnish father and a Thai mother, Joe spent much of his childhood attending Adventist schools. He learned Bible stories, sang hymns, and prayed before meals—but faith felt distant.

“I believed God existed,” he said. “But I didn’t know Him personally.”

When Joe was 13, his mother passed away. Though she had found Christian faith shortly before her death, the loss left Joe deeply confused and bitter. A youth group that had once felt like a refuge dissolved soon after, and his questions about God went unanswered.

“I didn’t understand why a loving God would take my mother, and then the youth group,” Joe said. “So, I walked away.”

For years, he searched elsewhere for belonging through parties, alcohol, and later alternative spiritual paths. Nothing lasted. What once numbed the pain eventually deepened it.

By his late twenties, Joe felt empty and exhausted. Depression and anxiety weighed heavily, and a painful breakup only intensified his despair.

“One night, I felt like the world had nothing left to offer me,” he said.

As Joe reached the lowest point of his



life, a single word impressed itself on his heart: *Pray*.

"I knew exactly who that prayer was meant for—the God I had learned about as a child," Joe said.

That night, Joe prayed honestly and desperately, asking God to take away his pain and give him life. Exhausted from months of sleeplessness, he fell asleep.

When he woke, something was different.

"The depression was gone," he said simply. "I knew it wasn't me. It had to be God."

Days later, biking to work in the cold winter darkness, Joe felt joy rising in his heart. "It felt like the sun was shining just for me," he said. With a grateful heart, he committed his life fully to God.

Not long afterward, Joe followed an invitation to OIKOS House.

"I had never experienced church like that," he said. "People listened. They wanted to know my story. There was no judgment—only belonging."

Joe stayed late that first Sabbath, sharing his testimony again and again with people who genuinely cared. From that day on, he knew he had found a spiritual family.

"What struck me most," Joe said, "was that OIKOS doesn't just talk about Jesus' teachings—it tries to live them."

Encouraged by the community that believed in him, Joe began to sense a new calling. Today, he is studying theology, preparing for pastoral ministry. His dream is to serve at OIKOS House and help plant new churches—places where others searching for belonging can encounter God just as he did.

"This house is just a tool," Joe reflected. "What matters is God's kingdom—and helping others discover the love that changed my life."

Looking back, Joe sees God's hand in every step, from seeds planted in childhood to a long, difficult walk toward a house where he finally found home. 🌍

Joe's journey reminds us that finding faith often begins with finding community.

Story Tips

- Show the location of Helsinki, Finland on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to Finland (see below)

Fast Facts

- The official name of Finland is the Republic of Finland.
- The capital and largest city of Finland is Helsinki.
- The Finnish name for Finland is *Suomi*.
- Finland's currency is the Euro.
- The official languages of Finland are Finnish and Swedish, although national languages like Sámi, Karelian, and Finnish Kalo are also recognized.
- The national anthem of Finland ("Our Land") can be sung in Finnish ("*Maamme*") and Swedish ("*Vårt land*").

Through ministries like OIKOS House, God is creating spaces where people burdened by loneliness, doubt, or fear can encounter genuine belonging and the healing love of Christ. Part of this quarter's Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will support OIKOS as it expands its outreach and prepares to plant new churches for the next generation. Thank you for your faithful giving.

“Change My Life”



FINLAND | October 17

Mikael

If You exist, change my life.”

It was a simple prayer from a discouraged teenager who felt trapped in habits he couldn’t break.

Mikael grew up in a Christian home in Finland, a fourth-generation Seventh-day Adventist on his father’s side. His mother discovered the Adventist faith through evangelistic meetings shortly after marrying Mikael’s father. When she later learned she was pregnant, she made a quiet promise to God: I will dedicate this child for Your service.

As a small child, Mikael sensed that dedication without fully understanding it. He remembers pretending to be a pastor at age three, holding “home church” services in his living room. He was baptized at 11 and felt sensitive to God’s leading. But soon after, his family moved to rural Finland, where the Adventist church was small and Mikael felt isolated—both as a believer and as part of an ethnic minority.

Wanting desperately to belong, he began smoking, drinking, and partying during his

early teen years. Weekends were filled with alcohol, and Sabbaths sometimes found him sitting in the back of church with a hangover. He never stopped believing in God, but he felt torn between faith and the pull of the world.

Adventist summer camps became a lifeline. Each year, Mikael felt drawn back to God—but once he returned to school, willpower alone wasn’t enough to change his habits. By age 15, his struggle reached its darkest point. “I made choices I deeply regretted,” he recalled. “It felt like a spiritual battle.”

At one camp, Mikael listened as a visiting speaker shared his testimony of transformation. Sitting in the back row, Mikael thought, When I’m 25, I’ll get my life together. Even then, beneath the confusion, he sensed a quiet calling—a purpose he couldn’t fully explain but couldn’t escape either.

The turning point came not through self-discipline, but surrender.

Late one night, after another weekend of



partying, Mikael looked at his reflection at a train station and asked himself, Who am I becoming? Back in his dorm room, he prayed honestly: “God, I love this lifestyle. I don’t even want to change. But if You want to, You have my permission.”

Not long after, he prayed again: “If You exist, change my life.”

God answered—not with dramatic emotion, but with quiet transformation. Mikael found himself longing for something different. He stopped his bad habits and began spending time with friends who took faith seriously. One evening, after praying with them, he felt no rush of emotion—yet everything changed. “I didn’t feel anything,” he said. “But I was never the same again.”

Soon after, God began stretching him in unexpected ways. One Sabbath afternoon, while bored and wandering through a shopping mall, Mikael felt impressed to speak to strangers about God. Though he felt unqualified, he obeyed. As he spoke, faith that once felt distant suddenly became real. “It was like God was teaching me as I spoke,” he said.

That experience marked the beginning of a journey into ministry.

After high school, Mikael joined a mission training program in Australia. There, a dream began to form: planting a church back home in Finland. In 2019, he contacted church leaders and joined early planning efforts for a new ministry in Helsinki.

Then came 2020.

The pandemic halted plans, separated Mikael from his girlfriend overseas, drained his finances, and plunged him into deep discouragement. Sleep-deprived and isolated, he questioned why God would give him such hope only to take it away. Yet even in that season, God was quietly at work.

That summer, a small team formed. Then a house became available with less than a month’s notice. By August 2020, the doors of Oikos House opened.

What began as a fragile step of faith has grown into a vibrant Seventh-day Adventist

Story Tips

- Show the location of Helsinki, Finland on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to Finland (see below)

Mission Post

- The brown bear is the national animal of Finland. The national bird is the swan, the national flower is the lily-of-the-valley, and the national tree is the silver birch.
- There are more than 168,000 lakes in Finland and 179,000 islands.
- Lapland is the largest and furthest-north region in Finland and is partly in the Arctic Circle. The Finnish name for Lapland is “*Lappi*” and in Swedish it is “*Lappland*.”

church plant. Each Sabbath, young adults gather in the home for Bible study, worship, shared meals, and fellowship. People come from many backgrounds, over 30 nationalities, creating a warm, welcoming space where faith feels real.

Over the past six years, hundreds have passed through Oikos House. Many have chosen baptism. Others have grown deeper in faith and stepped into leadership. Young people once searching for belonging have found a spiritual family.

Mikael sees God’s hand clearly now. Today, Oikos House is outgrowing its space. The dream is bigger now: to plant another church and raise up a new generation of young leaders who will serve across Finland and beyond. 🌍

This quarter, part of the Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will help support future church plants—branching off of the Oikos House—places where faith is lived around the table, prayers are honest, and lives are changed.

Never Alone

CROATIA | October 24

Pastor Dario



It was five o'clock in the morning on March 22, 2020, when Pastor Dario awoke with a start. He had not planned to rise so early, but suddenly he was fully awake—with a strong urge to sing.

Slipping quietly out of bed, he picked up his guitar and began singing, “I’m never alone, I’m never alone...”

For the next thirty minutes he sang the same words over and over. He did not know why.

Then he knelt beside his bed and began praying for the online evangelistic series he had been presenting during the COVID-19 pandemic. Each day he faithfully livestreamed messages of hope, yet viewership had been low. He prayed that somehow God would use the meetings to reach hearts.

After some time, he returned to bed. Lying on his back, arms stretched upward toward heaven, he continued praying, this time for his church members. He asked God to strengthen them, to encourage them, to hold them close.

Pastor Dario served the historic Zagreb 1 Seventh-day Adventist Church—the first

Adventist congregation in Croatia. Built in 1935, it was the first Adventist-owned worship space in the capital city. Dedicated members had constructed it during a time of legal and social challenges. The complex included a beautiful two-story sanctuary, Sabbath School rooms, offices, a library, publishing space, and several apartments located directly above the sanctuary.

Pastor Dario lived in one of those apartments.

At 6:34 a.m., as he lay there praying, the entire building began to shake violently.

Cabinets crashed. Walls cracked. The ground rolled beneath him.

But he felt at peace. He knew God was with him. The words he had just been singing filled his mind: *I’m never alone.*

“God, I’m ready,” he prayed. “Even if I die.”

When the shaking subsided, screams echoed from nearby buildings. The earthquake struck Zagreb with devastating force. Quickly dressing, Pastor Dario rushed outside, gathering neighbors and helping calm frightened residents. Many buildings in the city were damaged beyond repair, including the historic Zagreb 1 sanctuary.



By 10:00 a.m., his phone began ringing. Concerned family members urged him to leave the city.

"You should come home," his mother said. "They will close Zagreb."

Thinking it might be wise to leave temporarily, Pastor Dario began packing a suitcase.

Then he sensed a clear impression: *Where are you going?*

"Home," he answered aloud.

But the prompting continued: *No. Stop that. Go to your office.*

Unsure what he would find, he obeyed.

To his amazement, his office was intact. Even the small studio used to livestream the evangelistic meetings had not been damaged.

Soon the conference president arrived. Given the severity of the earthquake, he assumed the online meetings would need to pause.

But the technicians checked the equipment.

"We can still broadcast today," they said.

Turning to Pastor Dario, the president asked, "Are you willing to go live?"

"Yes," he replied without hesitation.

"I must."

That evening, as the program began, something remarkable happened.

Viewership surged. Thousands who were shaken, frightened, and searching for hope tuned in.

"So many people were watching and encouraged after what we had all just experienced," Pastor Dario later said. "It was crucial to continue. God used that tragedy to begin something new."

From that moment, online ministry expanded dramatically. Pastor Dario and several other Adventist pastors in Croatia launched YouTube channels that continue today—reaching thousands and leading to hundreds of Bible study interests.

Recognizing this growing digital outreach, Pastor Dario now serves as Media Ministries Director of the Adriatic Union Conference in the Trans-European Division.

Story Tips

- Show the location of Croatia on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to Croatia (see below)

Mission Post

- Croatia has 40 Seventh-day Adventist churches and 2,389 members. With a population of 3,851,000, that is one church member for every 1,612 Croatians.
- Croatia has no official religion, and freedom of religion is a constitutional right.
- Christians make up nearly 90 percent of the Croatian population. Around 80 percent of those are Catholic, 3 percent are Orthodox, and 5 percent other Christians. More than 10 percent are "no religion" or "other."

Although parts of the Zagreb 1 complex survived the earthquake, the historic sanctuary was damaged beyond repair and had to be demolished. Yet the church members have not stopped. They continue meeting in temporary spaces, worshiping faithfully, and sharing hope with their community as they look forward to building again. 🌍

This quarter, your Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will help construct a new sanctuary for the Zagreb 1 church family—a place where worship, evangelism, and outreach can flourish once more.

Thank you for helping our brothers and sisters in Croatia rebuild—not only walls, but a center of hope for their city.



“Show Me the Truth”

CROATIA | October 31

Nika

On weekday afternoons in Zagreb, laughter and quiet concentration fill a church library known as the “Prilaz School.” At one table sits Nika, patiently helping a child work through a difficult assignment. At another moment, she pauses and asks gently, “Shall we pray?”

For up to twelve students each week, Nika is more than a tutor. She is a steady presence—someone who listens, encourages, and points young hearts toward God.

One day a student’s mother was hospitalized unexpectedly. The children were worried. “Let’s pray for her,” Nika suggested. They did. Soon afterward, the mother recovered.

Another child, so happy in the warm atmosphere of the program, once declared, “I want to work here when I grow up!”

For Nika, moments like these are deeply meaningful. “I feel very fulfilled and very close to Jesus,” she says. “I know the Holy Spirit is leading me.”

But only a few years ago, her life looked very different.

Like most people in Croatia, Nika was raised in the country’s traditional religion. As a young adult, however, she began

searching for something more. Her spiritual curiosity led her into New Age teachings. She even traveled to India, exploring ideas about reincarnation and participating in elaborate rituals.

“But it was empty,” she recalls. “Nothing changed. I prayed, but everything stayed the same.”

What troubled her most was the inconsistency. “They talked about good things,” she says, “but they were not living them.”

Disillusioned and spiritually restless, Nika returned to Croatia feeling alone and without purpose. Then one day, she met an older woman who invited her to church.

There she received a Bible.

As she began reading, something caught her attention—the Sabbath. It seemed clear in Scripture.

“Why don’t you go to church on Saturday?” she asked the pastor.

“It’s not important,” he answered. “It’s only a day.”

But Nika could not ignore what she was discovering.

“It’s not only a day,” she thought.

She began praying: “Show me the truth.”

While searching online, Nika came across a YouTube channel addressing topics she had once wrestled with—reincarnation, creation, and the reliability of Scripture. The presentations made sense. She learned the speaker was a Seventh-day Adventist and would soon be lecturing at a local Adventist



church. She decided to attend.

Again, what she heard resonated deeply.

Even more, the people welcomed her warmly—especially Mileta, the church librarian, who asked if she would like to enroll in the Discovery Bible Correspondence School.

“I’ll do the lessons at home,” Nika replied, “and come once a week so we can talk.”

For three to four hours at a time, they studied together. Mileta introduced her to the writings of Ellen White, which Nika eagerly read. Truth was unfolding—clear, biblical, consistent.

When she became convicted about keeping the Sabbath, Nika made a difficult decision. She left her job and accepted night work as a security guard so she would be free during Sabbath hours. The long quiet shifts gave her time to read and reflect.

Finally, she knew she had found what she had been searching for.

Nika was baptized on December 16, 2023. Because the historic Zagreb 1 church building had been severely damaged in the 2020 earthquake, her baptism took place in another Adventist church.

Her family attended. Her stepfather, who had long claimed to be an atheist, told her afterward, “You are in the right place.” Just weeks later, he passed away. Nika treasures those words and continues praying for her mother and brothers.

Six months after her baptism, an unexpected opportunity came. The church’s Prilaz School, an after-school tutoring outreach begun during the pandemic, needed help, and Nika gladly responded to the need.

The program, supported by the Trans-European Division and the Croatian Conference, was designed to serve families overwhelmed by academic and social pressures.

Now, Nika helps children with homework—and gently introduces them to the God who changed her life.

She also drives a taxi part-time. In her car,

Story Tips

- Show the location of Croatia on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to Croatia (see below)

Fast Facts

- The official name of Croatia is the Republic of Croatia.
- The capital city of Croatia is Zagreb in the north of the country.
- Croatian is the official language of Croatia.
- The Euro is the currency of Croatia.
- Croatia’s coastline contains more than a thousand islands, only 48 of which are inhabited.
- The Pula Arena, in Pula, Croatia, is an ancient Roman amphitheater and is the only one in the world where the whole circular wall is still intact.

she keeps copies of Steps to Christ and health magazines, praying each day that God will send someone who is searching.

“Show me the truth,” she once prayed. Now she helps others find it.

Today, the members of Zagreb 1 continue meeting in temporary spaces while they look forward to rebuilding their church home—severely damaged in the 2020 earthquake. But while they wait, the mission continues. Through outreach projects like the Prilaz School, lives are being changed. 🌍

Your Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will help provide a new church building in Zagreb—a place where worship, Bible study, children’s programs, and community outreach can flourish again. It will be a spiritual home not only for members, but for seekers like Nika who are praying, “Show me the truth.”

Finding the Missing Piece



CROATIA | November 7

Goran

basketball, his mother began studying the Bible with Seventh-day Adventists and was baptized. Occasionally he attended church with her. Before he left for the United States, she gave him a Bible in English.

At university, he sometimes read it, especially Revelation, though he understood little. In difficult moments, he even prayed. But he never felt a personal relationship with God.

Now, back in Croatia and searching for purpose, he decided to try again.

"I told myself, I've tried everything else. The only thing left is to go back to the Bible and see about a life with God."

He began reading and praying earnestly. Wanting to find his own way rather than simply follow his mother's path, he attended a Sunday-keeping church. But one issue troubled him.

"The thorn in my eye was always the Sabbath," he said. "From childhood, I knew what the Bible said."

When his Bible study group reached Exodus 20, he listened carefully. The explanation of the fourth commandment was brief: "Our Sabbath is now Sunday." Then they moved on.

Goran was not convinced.

One night, pouring out his heart in prayer, he opened to Isaiah 58 and read about calling the Sabbath "a delight." The words struck him deeply. The conviction became clear.

He decided to visit the Zagreb 1 Seventh-day Adventist Church. He even invited his mother to come with him.

Basketball was Goran's life. From the age of 12, he thought about it, dreamed about it, and built his identity around one goal: becoming a professional player. After high school in Croatia, that dream seemed within reach when he received a basketball scholarship to the University of Maine at Fort Kent in the United States.

In northern Maine, Goran studied business management and trained intensely as part of the student-athlete program. But by his senior year, reality set in. He would not make it into the professional leagues.

"With my lifelong dream crushed," he said, "everything felt pointless."

He graduated with a Bachelor of Science degree and returned to Croatia, landing a job in tax consulting in Zagreb. Outwardly, he was successful. Inwardly, he was empty.

"I would be in a nightclub," he recalled, "and suddenly the thought would come: What am I doing here? This life is meaningless, too."

Goran had grown up in a good family. Around the time he became obsessed with



“As soon as I came,” he said, “I felt my heart was at home.”

He was ready for baptism, but one question remained: Ellen G. White.

Around this time, he met Daniela, a young woman at church who would later become his wife. Goran shared his concerns about Ellen White’s prophetic ministry.

“OK,” Daniela told him, “have your opinion. But watch just one video.”

The presentation carefully explained the biblical characteristics of a prophet. It made sense. Goran began reading for himself.

“The more I studied the Bible and her writings,” he said, “the more convinced I became that I was on the right path.”

He was baptized at Zagreb 1. Six months later, he and Daniela were married there.

“I finally found the missing piece,” he said. “I found it in Jesus.”

But the story did not end there.

Wanting others to experience the same joy, Goran and Daniela launched a Facebook outreach called “Giveaway Books.” They offered free copies of *The Great Controversy*, *The Desire of Ages*, and other Christian books—shipping included.

The response was overwhelming. More than 10,000 books have been distributed across Croatia. As interest grew, the Trans-European Division helped expand the project, and similar initiatives began in neighboring countries.

Goran and other young members of Zagreb 1 also adapted their printed Bible studies into an online course called “Bible Truth.” Thousands enrolled. One student, who had nearly abandoned his spiritual journey, is now studying to become a Seventh-day Adventist pastor.

Then, in 2020, a devastating earthquake struck Zagreb. The historic Zagreb 1 sanctuary—home to so many life-changing decisions—was damaged beyond repair and had to be demolished.

“It was heartbreaking,” Goran said. “But when we heard about the Thirteenth Sabbath Offering project, it gave us hope.”

Story Tips

- Show the location of Croatia on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to Croatia (see below)

Mission Post

- The Seventh-day Adventist message first entered the Balkan Peninsula, where Croatia is located, in 1880, when A. Seefried went to Skoplje in what is now the Republic of Macedonia.
- A branch publishing house was established around 1913 in Zagreb called *Zivot i zdravlje* (“Life and Health”) and remained active until World War II.
- The Seventh-day Adventist Church was not officially recognized by the Bulgarian government until 1990.
- After Croatia declared independence from Yugoslavia in the early 1990s, the *Znaci Vremena* (*Signs of the Times*) publishing branch in Zagreb became the Croatia-Slovenian Publishing House, now the Croatian Publishing House.
- Croatia is home to Adriatic Union College and the Adventist Secondary School in Marusevec.

The building may be gone, but the mission continues. The faith of this vibrant congregation remains strong. Through social media, online Bible studies, and personal witness, they are reaching more people than ever. 🌐

Your Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will help rebuild a new sanctuary in the heart of Zagreb: a place where searching hearts like Goran’s can find the missing piece. Thank you for giving generously so others can find their home in Jesus.

Space to Grow



CROATIA | November 14

Leon

Leon was seven years old the first time he went to Bible camp at Maruševec. His parents had gone to the same camp when they were children. It had been running since 1972—a summer tradition for Adventist families across Croatia.

For Leon, the first week changed everything.

“There were 50 to 100 children,” he remembers. “We had Bible school every day, workshops, singing, photography, and sports, and every evening after dinner we had worship.”

But what he remembers most is baseball.

Not American baseball exactly—their own version. Tennis balls. Improvised bases. A field filled with laughter. And a tradition more than fifty years old.

“We played every evening until nine,” Leon says. “That was the biggest thing of the camp!”

Each week ended with a Sabbath program prepared by the children: songs, dramas, and worship presentations for parents who came to see what their children had learned.

And every year, children brought their non-Adventist friends.

Last year, three young people were baptized at camp—two Adventists and one who had come as a guest. Camp was more than games. It was faith in action. And it planted something in Leon’s heart.

When Leon entered high school at Maruševec in 2018 to study physical therapy technology, something else had changed.

A brand-new boys’ dormitory had just opened—funded by a previous Thirteenth Sabbath Offering.

“It was special,” Leon says. “We didn’t have keys. We had cards. It was like a hotel.”

The old dormitory had four students per room. The new one had two. The new rooms also had air-conditioning, modern furniture, and shared bathrooms between two rooms.

“It was modern. Clean. Comfortable. And the student club was connected to the dorm.”

Nearby were basketball and volleyball courts—spaces where friendships formed naturally. For Leon’s generation, the new dormitory wasn’t just a building. It was home.

Some older students felt nostalgic for the old dorm. But for those who grew up in the new one, it became the center of student life: a place to study, laugh, talk about faith, and build community.



Students who came for vocational training also found something deeper—belonging.

As a child, Leon had once told his elementary school headmaster, “During the week I want to be a stonemason. On Sabbath I want to be a pastor.”

But in high school, he fell in love with sports, anatomy, and the human body. Physical therapy seemed like the obvious path. He completed his studies and was well prepared for further education.

Yet, during Leon’s final year of high school, a thought returned, quietly at first.

“I don’t know when,” he says, “but I started again to think about pastoral ministry.”

The thought did not leave. It grew.

Leon began talking with professors. With his girlfriend. With his parents. He prayed. He reflected. The sense of calling became clearer.

He enrolled in theology at Maruševac and completed his B.A. Today, at 24 years old and newly married, he is serving as a pastoral intern.

And he hasn’t forgotten Bible camp.

Over the years, he returned—first as a counselor caring for younger children, then as a Bible teacher, then as a lecturer.

He also helped launch and lead “Teen Connect,” a weekend spiritual retreat for teenagers across Croatia and Slovenia, because he noticed that although many programs existed for children, there were few specifically for teens.

“We always include mission activities,” he says. “Visiting elderly homes. Cleaning the campus. Distributing literature.”

He understands something important: the faith that shaped him was formed in community—in camps, dormitories, worship, and service.

When the new dormitory opened, no one could predict which boys would sleep there, or what God might call them to become. But the investment created space to grow, to belong, and to hear God’s voice.

Today, Leon ministers in Zagreb, helping lead Bible studies and youth programs—

Story Tips

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- Share facts related to Croatia (see below)

Fast Facts

- The inventor and engineer, Nikola Tesla, was born in 1856 in the village of Smiljan, in Croatia. His childhood home has been converted into a museum.
- On June 25, 1991, Croatia declared its independence from Yugoslavia, which led to the Croatian War of Independence.
- Seventeenth century Croatian mercenaries wore the first neckties. The French word for necktie, *cravate*, comes from the Croatian word *hrvatska*.
- The Sea Organ in Zadar combines beautiful architectural design with the beauty of nature. Constructed of pipes running under large marble steps leading down into the ocean, crashing waves push air through the tubes to create magical melodies.

part of a new generation of Croatian leaders shaped by Adventist education and community life. 🌐

The Thirteenth Sabbath Offering of the First Quarter of 2017 helped build the Maruševac dormitory, and students like Leon were shaped by that gift.

Now, in Zagreb, a church community displaced by earthquake damage is seeking to rebuild a place where youth, families, and seekers can gather in worship and ministry. Your offering helps create spaces where faith can grow and where God can call the next generation.

When a School Becomes a Mission Field



POLAND | November 21

Agata

For nearly 20 years, Agata taught Polish language and literature in public schools near Warsaw. She loved teaching, but over time she felt something was missing. Classes were crowded, lessons rushed, and there was little time to truly know students.

“I wanted something deeper,” Agata said. “Not just to teach a lesson and leave, but to really know my students—their needs, their talents, their families.”

By 2018, she knew it was time for a change.

That same year, a small group of Adventist parents began offering English classes for kindergarten-age children on a church campus. What started with a few families became a shared conviction: their children needed an Adventist school shaped by faith, relationships, and purpose.

The parents asked Agata if she would help.

The situation was uncertain. There was one classroom, and funding would last only

three months. Accepting the invitation meant leaving a stable teaching position, while carrying a mortgage and relying largely on her husband’s income.

“I prayed a lot,” she recalled. “It was one of the hardest decisions of my life.”

When she asked her husband for advice, his answer was simple: “Just try.”

Agata stepped forward in faith. Three months passed—and then more funding came. “We never had a moment when we didn’t have money,” she said. “God blessed it from the beginning, even though the beginning was very difficult.”

Out of that fragile start grew KOMPAS, an Adventist primary school and preschool serving children from grades 1 through 8. In just a few years, enrollment grew to 50 students in the primary school and 32 in preschool, supported by a team of teachers and staff who see their work as a calling.

Agata is quick to credit the team. “It’s not only a job,” she said. “We see this as a mission field.” Working together, they have shaped a school culture that is intentional and spiritually warm.

As the school developed, so did its philosophy. Adventist education, Agata and her colleagues realize, is not simply adding Bible time to a standard curriculum. It is educating the whole child—physically, emotionally, intellectually, and spiritually.

One key influence was outdoor education.



Bible lessons often start indoors and continue in nature, where children connect Scripture with what they see around them—clouds, trees, soil, and sky.

“When children are outside, they are in God’s creation,” Agata said. “They breathe fresh air, they move, their minds work better. And they understand that nature is something God made.”

Montessori-based methods also help teachers meet each child where they are. Younger students work at their own pace with hands-on materials, guided as needed.

Faith at KOMPAS extends beyond the classroom. Students serve their community—visiting elderly neighbors, sharing handmade cards with Bible verses, and singing for people who might otherwise feel alone.

Fridays look different too. Students work in gardens and around the campus—painting, sweeping, raking, collecting wood—and seeds in the soil become lessons about God’s Word. The week often ends with a shared campfire, where preschoolers and older students gather, talk, and play together.

Over time, Agata and her colleagues noticed change in the children themselves.

“The spirit here changes children’s hearts,” she said. “We see it in how they speak to one another, how they think about whether their words will hurt someone. Even first graders show empathy. We know the Holy Spirit is working.”

One rainy day made that especially clear. During a planned outing, the weather turned miserable. As Agata worried aloud, two eight-year-olds—her daughter and a classmate—offered a solution. “Don’t worry,” they said. “We will pray.”

They did. The rain stopped.

“For them, prayer is the first response,” Agata said. “They believe God listens—and they see the results.”

Today, Agata serves as the school’s principal, a role she once resisted because she wanted to remain close to students. Yet the calling is clear.

“This is not just a school,” she often says.

Story Tips

- Show the location of Poland on a map.
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- Share facts related to Poland (see below)

Mission Post

- Poland has 117 Seventh-day Adventist churches, 33 companies, and 6,032 members. With a population of 37,565,000, that is one church member for every 6,228 Poles.
- Poland is one of the most religious countries in Europe, and Catholicism remains an important part of Polish society.
- More than 70 percent of Poles are Catholic, 21 percent claim no affiliation, and 7 percent have no religion. Other Christian denominations only make up 1 percent of the population.
- The first Adventist workers, J. Laubhan and H. Szkubowicz moved to eastern Poland from Crimea. By 1893, the first church in what then was the territory of Poland was established.

“It is a mission field.”

At KOMPAS, children are being shaped to live with Christ-centered compassion wherever they go. “This education is eternal,” Agata reflected. “It begins here, but it continues into heaven.” 🌍

Now the school is growing again and space is limited. Plans are underway to add a new level with several classrooms and other needed facilities so more children can learn in this Christ-centered environment. Part of your Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will go to help build this addition to the KOMPAS school.

Agata is confident that just as God led from the beginning, He will continue to lead through prayer, dedicated educators, and the generosity of believers around the world.

Opening the Bible— Opening Hearts



POLAND | November 28

Monika

Monika never planned to teach at an Adventist school.

Her journey to the classroom began almost by accident during a conversation at a wedding in 2022. Someone asked if she could teach history at KOMPAS Adventist Primary School. She wasn't sure, but she did have a deep love for history, experience educating her own children through homeschooling, and years spent learning alongside other families in a small home-education community.

"I knew what was expected in the curriculum," Monika said. "And I knew how children learn."

She agreed to try.

Today, Monika teaches history from grades 4 through 8. She is also the main classroom teacher for grades 5 and 6, staying with her students as they move up—a continuity that allows her to know them well. She also teaches some Polish. "We're growing together," she said.

Her classroom is anything but typical.

The students come from many backgrounds and belief systems: Adventist, Catholic, Calvinist, atheist, Buddhist, Hare Krishna. Some openly talk about reincarnation. Many have special learning needs. It is a mix that might intimidate some teachers. Monika isn't worried.

"You just move forward," she said.

When she first stepped into her role as a main teacher, she recognized an immediate challenge: if Bible time was going to be meaningful, the students first needed to trust the Bible itself. So instead of beginning with familiar stories, she began with questions.

For nearly a month, the class explored why the Bible claims authority and how Scripture describes itself as light, truth, and a living word. Students opened their own Bibles daily, reading passages and comparing what the Bible says about itself.

"We try not to have a day when we don't



open the Bible,” Monika explained. “And we always explain clearly that what we are saying comes from Scripture.”

That approach was shaped by a moment she will never forget.

On the first day of school, as she explained the daily schedule, one boy raised his hand. “Can you believe in God and not in the church?” he asked.

It was not an easy question. Monika went home and thought about it for a long time. Finally, she knew how to answer.

“Yes,” she told him. “I was a person like that for many years.”

That answer opened the door for something deeper.

Monika understands doubt because she lived it. She was raised by an atheist father who openly mocked religion. Loving him, she adopted his views. As a teenager, she believed faith was an illusion—until one quiet evening changed everything.

Sitting alone at her desk one night at age sixteen, she began thinking about the world and how it worked. “It couldn’t have happened by itself,” she realized. In the darkness, she whispered what she now recognizes as her first prayer: *If there is an Almighty Power, show Yourself to me.*

That prayer cracked the door open.

God’s answers came slowly—through books, friendships, and unexpected encounters. She bought her first Bible almost casually, placing it untouched on a shelf. Later, through friends exploring faith during Poland’s final years under communism, she began attending meetings, asking questions, and opening Scripture for herself.

Some paths led to dead ends. Others revealed truth mixed with error. But one thing became clear: the Bible could be trusted, and Jesus was real.

Eventually, Monika attended Adventist evangelistic meetings in Warsaw. She learned biblical teachings she had never encountered before. Finally, one June day just after finishing her high school exams, she was baptized.

Story Tips

- Show the location of Poland on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to Poland (see below)

Fast Facts

- The official name of Poland is the Republic of Poland.
- The capital and largest city of Poland is Warsaw.
- The official language of Poland is Polish.
- The Polish currency is the Złoty.
- The name for Poland in Polish is *Polska*, meaning field or flatland.
- Poland has around 10,000 lakes. The largest are Śniardwy and Mamry, while the deepest is Lake Hańcza at 356 feet (108.5 m) deep.

That journey shaped her life. It also shapes her teaching.

“When students ask hard questions, I’m not afraid,” Monika said. “I’ve been there.”

Today, many of her students have never heard basic Bible stories—stories Adventist children often know by heart. Monika introduces them gently, sometimes using *My Bible Friends* books, building a shared foundation of Scripture and trust.

In her classroom, faith is never forced. It is offered clearly, consistently, and lovingly. 🌍

Your Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will make a big impact at the KOMPAS school, allowing the school to expand by adding 200 square meters (2,153 square feet). This will give much needed additional space for this growing school. Thank you for helping to support mission!

A School That Became a Refuge



POLAND | December 5

Zhanna

When war forced Zhanna and Victor to leave their home in Ukraine, they carried with them little more than their children and their faith. Like many families fleeing conflict, they did not know where they would land or how long the journey would last.

What Zhanna did know was that she wanted her children to continue growing up with Adventist education.

In Ukraine, Adventist schools are well established, and the Chuprun family had hoped their three children would be educated in a faith-centered environment. But war closed doors they never imagined would close. As refugees, their future felt uncertain, and choices were limited.

When the family arrived in Poland, they were given temporary refuge on a church campus that included a young Adventist school—KOMPAS. For Zhanna,

discovering that an Adventist preschool and primary school existed there felt like an answer to prayer.

But another obstacle stood in the way: money.

Like many refugee families, the Chupruns had no financial margin. Tuition at a private school was beyond their reach. Still, Zhanna prayed. She longed for at least one of her children to attend the school.

The youngest child was accepted into the preschool at a significantly reduced fee. Zhanna was grateful, but her heart remained heavy for her older children, who had to attend public schools instead.

Determined to contribute however she could, Zhanna began working on campus, cleaning buildings. Victor helped with maintenance and construction projects. They worked faithfully, quietly, and gratefully, never assuming more would be possible.



Story Tips

- Show the location of Poland on a map.
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- Share facts related to Poland (see below)

Fast Facts

- Several Poles are renowned in the history of science and technology. Nicolaus Copernicus (1473–1543) showed scientifically that the sun was the center of the solar system rather than the Earth. Maria Skłodowska-Curie, or Marie Curie (1867–1934), was a Polish pioneer in radioactivity research. She was the first woman to win a Nobel Prize, and the first person to win twice.
- Warsaw was almost completely destroyed by bombs in World War II. After the war, the city was rebuilt based on eighteenth-century paintings by the Venetian artist, Bernardo Bellotto.
- Poland has the first upside down house. Built in a forest, visitors enter through the attic windows.

But Zhanna continued to pray.

Her greatest hope was for her daughter, Sofia, to attend the Adventist school. When school leaders learned of the family's situation, they searched for a solution. A request was submitted to ASI (Adventist-Laymen's Services & Industries) explaining that refugee children longed for Adventist education but could not afford the cost.

The answer came back with unexpected generosity.

Funding was provided to help Sofia attend the school for an entire year. With the additional support, her tuition was reduced to a level the family could manage. "It was Zhanna's dream," one teacher said, "to have her child here."

Sofia joined the school and flourished.

Two or three years later, with continued support, the family's oldest son also enrolled. The Chupruns now had all three children learning in an environment shaped by faith, kindness, and purpose.

For Sofia, school quickly became more than lessons and homework. It became belonging.

One year, students were invited to participate in swimming classes—an optional activity that required an extra fee. Sofia wanted to join, but her family could not afford it. When a teacher learned of the situation, she quietly stepped in and paid for Sofia to attend the classes for the entire year.

No announcement was made. No recognition was sought. It was simply an act of compassion—one of many that define the spirit of the school.

For families like the Chupruns, Adventist education is not a luxury. It is stability in a season of upheaval. It is spiritual grounding when everything else feels uncertain. It is a reminder that even in displacement, they are not forgotten.

The Chuprun children—Nahum, Sofia, and Natan—are now growing, learning, and serving alongside classmates from Poland and beyond. They study Scripture, learn outdoors, serve their community, and

experience faith not only as belief, but as lived practice.

Their story is one among many.

For Zhanna, the answer to her prayers did not come all at once. It came step by step—through a school, a community, generous hearts, and a God who listens. And for her children, it came in the form of a place to belong. 🌍

KOMPAS is much more than just a school. It is a place where children feel safe to learn and grow in a supportive environment, where they are encouraged to grow closer to God and to each other. Thank you for supporting mission by giving generously to the Thirteenth Sabbath Offering.

Music That Opens Doors

UNITED KINGDOM | December 12

Fiona



When Fiona was first asked in 2014 to lead a new music outreach project in East London, she hesitated.

The idea had come from leaders of the East London Seventh-day Adventist churches who were discussing how to create centers of influence in their communities. Health and education were mentioned. Then someone suggested a music school. Pastor David Burnett, who knew Fiona from her work directing large choirs and orchestras—including 25 years of annual *Messiah* performances—put her name forward.

At first, she was unsure. “I had thought about starting something in North London,” she said. “But that didn’t work out.”

Still, she lived in East London. After prayer and reflection, she agreed.

On April 5, 2015, the East London School of Classical Music (ELSOM) opened its doors at Clapton Seventh-day Adventist Church in the London Borough of Hackney. They began with four teachers and about ten students. Recruitment happened mostly by word of mouth and church announcements.

From the beginning, the vision had two pathways: strengthening music within

the Adventist Church and reaching the wider community.

At first, most students came from local congregations, but after a simple website launched in 2016, more non-Adventist families began enrolling. Then the pandemic changed everything.

While many programs paused, ELSOM continued. An IT-specialist parent helped set up Google Classroom so students could submit music theory assignments and arrange online lessons. About half the students adapted to the new format. “We didn’t want the children doing nothing,” Fiona explained. “Music gave them structure and hope.”

During that same period, another outreach was operating in the church building: the E5 Baby Bank, which supported more than 300 struggling families with food, clothing, and essentials. As families entered the building, they heard classical music drifting down the hallway.

“Classical music has a therapeutic effect,” Fiona said. “Parents would ask about the sound.”

Referrals began coming from social services, mental health support agencies, and family support networks. Fiona personally accepted several children referred through the Baby Bank, many from refugee or vulnerable backgrounds.

In 2021, ELSOM registered as a charity, formally strengthening its mission to provide classical music education for disadvantaged families. Grants from the South England Conference, the British Union Conference, and external funding bodies began helping



to subsidize lessons.

Today, the school has grown from ten students to 150. Twelve teachers now serve, some in person and some online, with students joining not only from East London but from Wales, Scotland, and beyond.

One of the school's largest achievements came in 2024, when the Arts Council awarded 10,000 British Pounds for a 17-week orchestra project for children and youth aged eight to nineteen. Fifty-three young people participated. Two performances followed: one at the Clapton Seventh-day Adventist Church and another at the Royal College of Music.

In April 2025, ELSOM celebrated its tenth anniversary with a week of special events. The highlight came when a member of the Royal Family—the Duchess of Gloucester—visited the Clapton Church, listened to a twenty-minute orchestra performance, and spent an hour visiting with the students.

Behind the scenes, partnerships continue to grow. Through a connection with the organization “Nucleo,” ELSOM has received more than thirty donated instruments—violins, violas, woodwinds, brass, keyboards, and even a white double bass. A cousin of Fiona's helped secure the long-term loan of a full set of timpani, saving the charity hundreds of pounds in rental fees per concert.

“At the moment,” Fiona laughs, “my living room looks like a music warehouse.”

But space has become the school's greatest limitation. Operating primarily on Sundays and limited weekday evenings at the church, ELSOM has waiting lists and receives new inquiries every week. Fiona and her team are currently exploring the lease of a larger space.

“Our mission is to reach more communities,” she said. “Music is the medium. Through classical music, people who are not of our faith come to know who we are.”

Students range in age from five to eighty-five. Some are beginners holding a violin for the first time. Others are retirees studying advanced music theory. A new initiative called “Generations United” now brings

Story Tips

- Show the location of the United Kingdom on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to the United Kingdom (see below)

Mission Post

- The first Seventh-day Adventist workers to Britain were John N. Loughborough and his wife, Annie, who arrived in Southampton, England in 1878.
- Soon after arriving in Britain, Loughborough adopted the motto “Onward, and no room for discouragement for those who humbly labor in God's cause.”
- Although progress was slow, by the time the Loughboroughs returned to the United States in 1883, 100 people had been baptized.

together seniors, carers, children, and families in choirs and orchestras, loaning instruments so finances do not become a barrier.

For Fiona, the purpose remains simple: “It's about passing on opportunities we were given to those who otherwise might never have them.” 🌍

This quarter, your Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will help minister to children and families through another community-based project: “Safe Space2Be” hubs—spaces developed in community schools in partnership with local Adventist churches. These welcoming environments will provide chaplaincy care, mentoring, well-being support, and practical outreach to students and their families. Each hub will function as a small center of influence where communities can encounter compassion, stability, and the love of Christ in practical ways. Thank you for supporting this ministry by giving generously.

More than Music



UNITED KINGDOM | December 19

Kieron

When Kieron first picked up a violin at age four, it wasn't entirely his idea.

His older brother had already begun lessons, and their mother had one clear rule: "If you're going to play the violin, play it properly."

Kieron did.

Born in London, he spent seventeen years growing up in Grenada before returning to the UK in 2019. His mother believed the move would give her sons greater opportunity. "She didn't want us to hit a glass ceiling," he said. "She wanted us to experience more."

Music became that pathway.

By age thirteen, Kieron was already teaching piano and violin. He led rehearsals, coached ensembles, and developed a reputation for discipline and excellence. "I had the highest grade in my group and was the most committed," he said. Responsibility came naturally.

When he returned to London, he contacted Fiona at the East London School of Classical Music (ELSOM). His brother had

studied there years earlier and knew the director well. Kieron called and simply asked if there was a job.

"There was," he said with a smile. "She needed a theory teacher."

Music theory, he insists, is essential. "It's like learning a language. There's no point speaking French if you can't read it. Music is the same—you must understand it."

That understanding has shaped his entire career. Today, at 27, Kieron plays seven instruments: violin, viola, cello, double bass, piano, bass guitar, and clarinet. His strong theoretical foundation allows him to move between them with confidence.

"It's easy to play music," he said. "It's not always easy to understand it."

At ELSOM, his role has expanded. What began as teaching theory grew into leading the strings section of the orchestra and eventually serving as Assistant Music Director. He plans repertoire, conducts sectionals, steps in to conduct when needed, and mentors young musicians.

About 75 students study under his guidance. The string section alone includes more than 20 players.

But for Kieron, music is never just about notes.



"I've had students who wouldn't speak at all when they first came," he said. "Now they're confident and expressive. It's not just about music—it's about the relationship."

Music, he believes, reveals character.

"If a child is timid, you hear it in their playing. If they're careless, you hear it. If they're diligent, you hear that too. Music amplifies personality—you can't hide from it."

That honesty shaped him as well. As a child, frustration sometimes led him to hit the piano when he made mistakes. His mother would calmly tell him to "put water in your wine"—to dilute his intensity and learn patience.

Music became a mirror.

"When you're struggling with a passage, you have to ask: Is it the music—or is it me?" he reflected. "Sometimes it's just your personality."

Over the years, he has watched former students perform at venues like the Royal Albert Hall in London and respond to calls for professional recording sessions. Seeing their growth gives him deep satisfaction.

"Legacy matters," he said. "It's a way of saying I was here. I left something behind."

His faith is woven into his music. Favorite hymns include "Come Thou Fount," "It Is Well," and "Great Is Thy Faithfulness." He believes sacred music shapes the heart as much as technique shapes the hands.

Music, he says, forces you to feel what you might otherwise avoid. Even struggle has beauty. "The intrinsic reward outweighs the suffering," he said. "And sometimes the suffering itself becomes art."

At ELSOM, he sees more than scales and sonatas. He sees confidence forming, discipline developing, faith strengthening.

"It's not just about learning an instrument," he said. "It's about becoming someone." 🌍

Seventh-day Adventists are touching the lives of children and young people in a powerful way across the United Kingdom. This Thirteenth Sabbath, you can help children in England who may not be able

Story Tips

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Fast Facts

- The United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland is usually known as the United Kingdom (UK) or simply Britain.
- Although the terms are often used interchangeably, the UK is a political entity; Great Britain refers to the territory of the island containing England, Scotland, and Wales; and the British Isles includes the islands of Great Britain, Ireland, and the many smaller surrounding islands.
- The capital of the UK is London, in England.
- The currency of the UK is the Pound sterling, meaning it is based on sterling silver, rather than gold.
- In 1884, the Royal Greenwich Observatory in London was chosen as the prime meridian, dividing the world into the East and West Hemispheres.
- The first postage stamp in the world was issued in the UK in 1840.
- London has the oldest subway system, opened in 1863.

to attend a school like ELSOM but need someone to care about them. This quarter's offering will help the Seventh-day Adventist Church in the UK to create small centers, "Safe Space2Be" for children in community schools across England who may feel worried, lonely, or afraid. These mental health hubs will provide counseling and other supportive services for at-risk children and their families. Thank you for your support.

Dedicated to Serve



13th SABBATH | December 26

Yeron

When Yeron first joined the East London School of Classical Music (ELSOM) nearly seven years ago, he simply wanted to learn the violin. He did not realize that the discipline of music would shape not only his skill but his faith.

He began with violin. Last year he added trumpet. Alongside performance, he studies music theory, learning to calculate rhythms, analyze musical passages, and understand structure and harmony.

“Sometimes, we face challenges,” he said thoughtfully. “Even when you know the theory, you still have to apply it.”

That lesson, he admits, applies far beyond music.

Now a university student studying business at London Metropolitan University, Yeron continues to serve faithfully at his home church in Tottenham. His brother plays the piano. Yeron plays the violin. Together they regularly lead music for worship services.

“We dedicated ourselves in the church to serve God,” he said simply.

Growing up in a Christian home, music was never merely entertainment. His mother, who once sang as a young woman in Ethiopia, insists on discipline and commitment. His father loves hymns, especially those that point to Christ’s return. On Friday evenings, the family gathers for worship—singing, praying, and playing together.

Those habits formed something steady inside him.

ELSOM gave Yeron opportunities he never expected. He has performed in churches across London, participated in orchestra concerts in the heart of London, and even played before HRH The Duchess of Gloucester during the school’s tenth anniversary celebrations.

“It was a big moment,” he said. “But the best part is that the songs we play always praise the Lord.”

His violin teacher carefully selects repertoire that reflects Christian values. Christmas programs are filled with hymns celebrating Christ’s birth. Sacred music is not an afterthought—it is central.



"It has greatly impacted my faith positively for the Lord," Yeron said. "There's no way we can perform songs that don't reflect God."

Performance exams, however, can be intimidating. External Trinity College examiners assess each student. Standards are high, and distinctions are expected.

"It's scary at first," he admitted, "but over time it gets easier."

Through music, Yeron has learned perseverance; through public performance, confidence; through sacred repertoire, spiritual commitment.

He has also seen how music shapes character. Discipline in practice spills into discipline in life. Attention to detail builds responsibility. Working within an orchestra teaches cooperation and humility.

"In music, you can't hide," he explained. "You have to do your part well so everyone else can succeed."

In a city as large and busy as London, where distractions and pressures are constant, ELSOM has provided something steady and purposeful: a community grounded in excellence and faith.

Today, Yeron sees music not just as a skill, but as ministry.

"I just think ELSOM is amazing," he said. "You learn a lot. The teachers help us through difficulties. And we use what we learn to serve God."

His dedication to excellence, to discipline, and above all to Christ, continues to grow.

Young people like Yeron are strengthened when faith and community work together. 🌍

This Thirteenth Sabbath, you can help children in England who may not be able to attend a school like ELSOM but need someone to care about them. This quarter's offering will help to create a SafeSpace2Be for children in community schools who may feel worried, lonely, or afraid. The offering will also go to three other projects in the Trans-European Division, including: A family Misson Center OIKOS church plant in Helsinki, Finland; expansion of KOMPAS, the

Story Tips

- Show the location of the United Kingdom on a map.
- Download photos for this story from Facebook: bit.ly/fb-mq.
- Share facts related to the United Kingdom (see below)

Mission Post

- The British Union Conference was organized in 1903, with a membership of 1,160.
- There are seven Adventist schools in Britain: Newbold College of Higher Education, Stanborough Park Secondary School, Stanborough Park Primary School, Newbold School, Hyland House School, Harper Bell School, and Flete Wood School.

Fast Facts

- The official language of the UK is English, although there are recognized regional languages, including Scots, Ulster Scots, Scottish Gaelic, Welsh, Cornish, and Irish.
- The Kingdom of Great Britain was formed by the Acts of Union in 1707 when the Kingdoms of England and Scotland united.
- In 1800, another Act of Union united Great Britain with the Kingdom of Ireland. Although most of the island of Ireland has become an independent country, the northern part of the country remains part of the United Kingdom.
- The water separating the UK from the rest of Europe is known as the English Channel, while the water between Ireland and the rest of Britain is called the Irish Sea.

first Adventist Primary School in Poland; and rebuilding the Seventh-day Adventist Church building in Zagreb, Croatia, Thank you for giving generously to the Thirteenth Sabbath offering this Sabbath!

Before 13th Sabbath

- Remind everyone that our mission offerings are gifts to spread God's Word around the world and that one-fourth of our Thirteenth Sabbath Offering, also known as the Quarterly Mission Project Offering, will help four projects in the Trans-European Division. The projects are listed on page three and on the back cover.
- The narrator doesn't need to memorize the story, but he or she should be familiar with it.
- Before or after the story, use a map to show the places in the Trans-European Division—Finland, Poland, Croatia, and the United Kingdom—that will receive the Thirteenth Sabbath Offering.



Thank you for your generous support of the Thirteenth Sabbath Offering. In the first quarter of 2017, these funds helped provide a much-needed men's dormitory at the Seventh-day Adventist secondary school in Maruševac, about 80 minutes north of Zagreb, Croatia. This quarter, your offerings will help rebuild the Prilaz Seventh-day Adventist Church in Zagreb. Thank you for faithfully supporting your brothers and sisters in Croatia through your giving.



Next Quarter's Mission Projects

The West-Central Africa Division will be featured next quarter, and the special projects will include:

- Establishing a Center of Influence at the Prince Emmanuel International Academy in Abidjan, Côte d'Ivoire (Ivory Coast).
- Providing a Health Clinic in Praia, Cabo Verde
- Building the Prince Emmanuel Children's School in Bata, Equatorial Guinea

Leader's Resources

Be sure to download your FREE *Mission Spotlight* video featuring video reports from around the Trans-European Division and beyond. Download or stream from the Adventist Mission website at bit.ly/missionspotlight.

Online Information

Following are sources of information that may be helpful in preparing for the mission segment of Sabbath School. For more information on the cultures and history of the countries featured in this quarterly, visit:

Websites

Croatia: government website
Croatia National Tourist Board
Visit Croatia
Lonely Planet

Finland: government website
Visit Finland
Finland Travel Info
Rough Guides

Poland: government website
Polish Tourism Organization
Poland Travel
Lonely Planet

United Kingdom: government website
Visit Britain
Trip Savvy
Trip Advisor

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gov.pl
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poland.travel/en
bit.ly/LP_Poland
gov.uk
visitbritain.com/en
bit.ly/TripSavvyUK
bit.ly/TripAdvUK

Seventh-day Adventist

Trans-European Division
Croatian Conference
Finland Union of Churches Conference
Polish Union Conference
East Polish Conference
South Polish Conference
West Polish Conference
British Union Conference
Irish Mission
North England Conference
Scottish Mission
South England Conference
Welsh Mission
Newbold College

ted.adventist.org
adventisti.hr
adventist.fi
adwent.pl
adwentysci.org.pl
poludnie.adwent.pl
zaufanie.pl
adventist.uk
adventist.ie
nec.adventist.uk
adventist.scot
sec.adventist.org.uk
wm.adventist.uk
newbold.ac.uk

An offering goal device will help focus attention on world missions and increase weekly mission giving. Determine a goal for your class's weekly mission offering. Multiply it by 14, allowing a double goal for the Thirteenth Sabbath Offering, which will be collected on December 26. Remind members that their regular weekly mission offerings help the missionary work of the world church, and that one-quarter of the Thirteenth Sabbath Offering will go directly to the projects in the Trans-European Division. On December 19, report on mission giving during the quarter. Encourage members to double or triple their normal mission giving on the upcoming Thirteenth Sabbath. Count the offering and record the amount given at the end of Sabbath School.

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youth & adult mission

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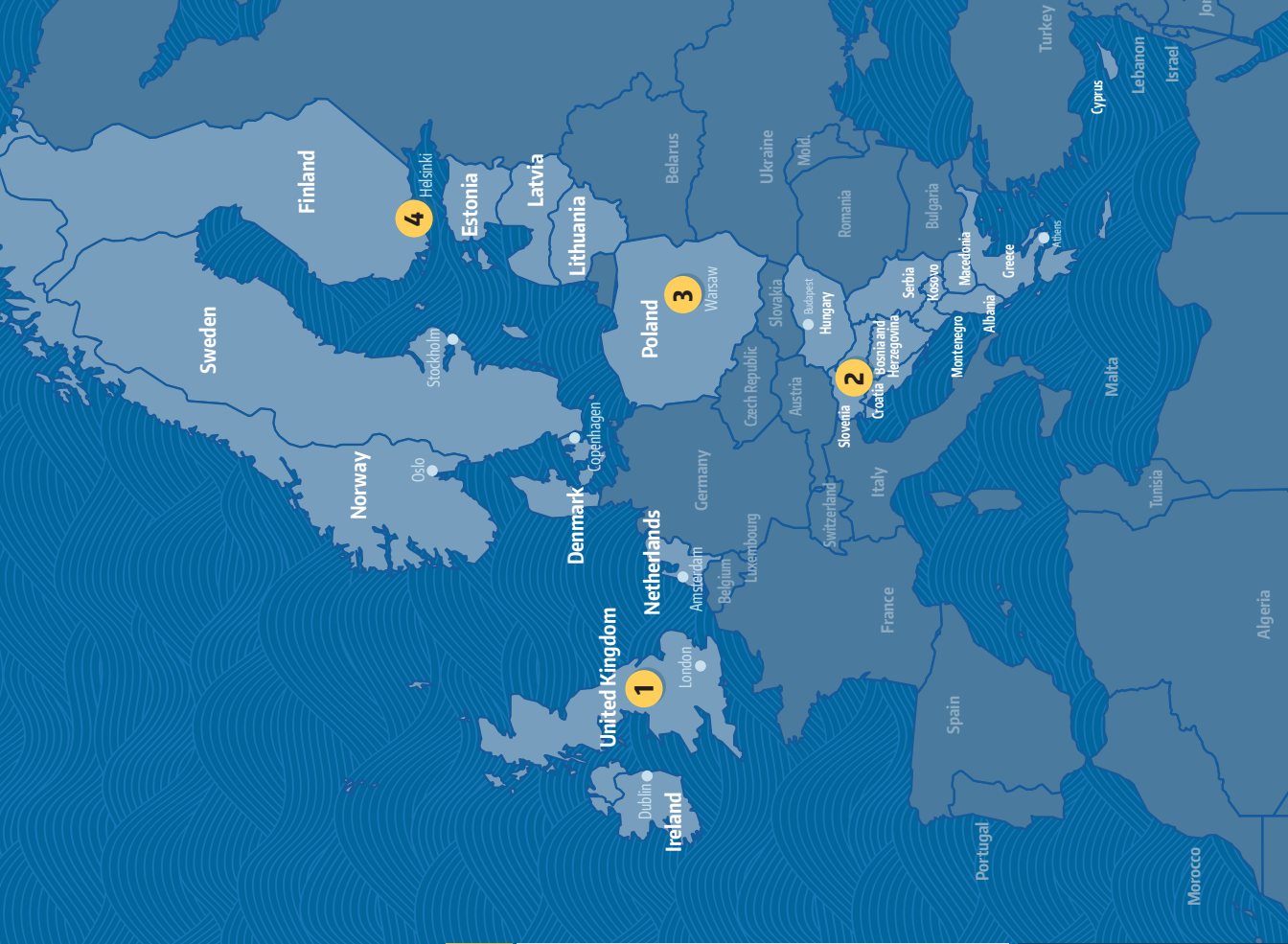
Fourth Quarter 2026

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Greenland

TRANS-EUROPEAN DIVISION

UNIONS	CHURCHES	COMPANIES	MEMBERSHIP	POPULATION
Adriatic	80	4	3,400	8,769,000
Baltic	87	8	5,437	6,147,000
British	309	113	43,754	74,951,000
Danish	40	1	2,349	6,087,000
Finland	58	9	4,115	5,624,000
Hungarian	109	21	5,009	9,577,000
Netherlands	59	15	6,218	17,989,000
Norwegian	59	2	4,538	5,581,000
Polish	118	33	5,995	37,565,000
South-East European	207	6	6,613	14,112,000
Swedish	32	7	2,954	10,564,000
ATTACHED FIELDS				
Cyprus Region	3	1	147	1,005,000
Greek Mission	11	4	455	9,935,000
Iceland Conference	6	1	512	388,000
Totals	1,178	225	91,496	208,294,000

PROJECTS

- 1 Mental Health Outreach for Children and Youth, England, U.K.
- 2 Prilaz Church Building, Zagreb, Croatia
- 3 Primary School Expansion, Podkowa Leśna, Poland
- 4 Family Mission Center, Helsinki, Finland